X—A Lamp for the Dark World

‘I see in 990 two conjunctions,
I see the sign of Mahdi and that of Antichrist;
Either politics or religion must change,
I clearly see the hidden secret.’

– Abdul Qadir Badauni, *Muntakhab-ut-Tawarikh*

In 1578, when Akbar stopped the rain, the world was only two years away from the last decade of the Islamic millennium; the last Mahdi must already be walking the earth. Akbar, apparently, decided it was him.

So much of a person’s character and destiny is woven with gossamer thread; a translucent, finely connected tapestry of instinct and belief, chance and determination, only parts of which are ever clearly visible in any particular light. One part, then, of Akbar’s messianic impulse was that such claims were quite common. As Azfar Moin has argued in his account of what he calls ‘sacred sovereignty . . . practiced by Muslim dynasts in early modern India and Iran’, Akbar’s ‘critics considered his spiritual pretensions to be far from original’. Shah Ismail, first of the Persian Safavids, had done very much the same. It might seem counter-intuitive to modern readers, writes Moin, to imagine ‘Muslim kings transmuting into saints and messiahs, venerated by courtiers and worshipped by soldiers’, such blasphemy going against the caricatured idea of Muslim rulers being rigidly orthodox.

In fact, writes Moin, ‘“heretical” conceptions of sacred authority attracted Muslim monarchs more than “orthodox” notions of Islam’.[1]

It’s not hard to understand why: no emperor would baulk at being worshipped. If Akbar became ‘inclined to claim the dignity of a prophet’, or, as Badauni mutters darkly, ‘perhaps I should say, the dignity of something else’,[2] he was also reinforcing his authority vis-à-vis his reluctant mansabdars. The miracles that he was increasingly willing to perform,

the accounts of visions and apparitions that he did nothing to discourage, these were, perhaps, the ‘symbolic acts’ that J.F. Richards refers to in his classic essay on Akbar’s formulation of imperial authority, acts by which Akbar created a ‘metaphor of the Emperor’s person as an embodiment of